Faith, Love, and Hope in Colossae

Writing from prison to a church he had never seen, Paul greets the Colossians with grace and peace and thanks God for the faith, love and hope the true gospel produced in them — the foundation for a letter that exalts Christ as all-sufficient.

Where this study fits

Colossians · twelve studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–8
Faith, Love, and Hope in Colossae

02 1:9–14
Paul’s Prayer for the Colossians

03 1:15–23
The Savior of the Gospel

04 1:24–29
Christ in You, the Hope of Glory

05 2:1–7
The Believer’s Education

06 2:8–15
Beware of Philosophy

07 2:16–23
Run the Race Set Before You

08 3:1–11
Looking Up, Putting Off

09 3:12–17
Service Manual for the Lord’s Army

10 3:18–4:1
The Relationships of the New Man

11 4:2–6
Perfecting the Prayer Life

12 4:7–18
Portrait of a Ministry Team

How the gospel reached Colossae

Background I.A · The church Paul had never seen (1:4, 7–8; 2:1)

Paul at Ephesus	All Asia hears	Epaphras	The Lycus Valley	Paul in Rome
Three years in Ephesus; two of them teaching daily in the school of Tyrannus	“All who lived in Asia heard the word of the Lord, both Jews and Greeks”	A Colossian who apparently heard Paul and carried the message home	Churches born in Colossae, Laodicea and Hierapolis, about a hundred miles east	Under guard in rented quarters, he writes to a church he has never seen
Acts 19:9–10	Acts 19:10	Col 1:7; 4:12	Col 4:13	Acts 28:30

Paul did not have to go everywhere himself — God multiplied His Word through a faithful learner who became a teacher.

Five marks of the Colossian heresy

Background I.B · An early form of Gnosticism

1 Jewish · 2:11, 16

Old Testament laws, foods, festivals and Sabbaths

2 Philosophical · 2:3–4, 8

γνῶσις
A deeper knowledge for the initiated

3 Angel worship · 2:18

Angels as mediators between man and God

4 Exclusive · 1:28; 3:11

“Perfection” for a select spiritual elite

5 Christological · 1:15–19; 2:9

It diminished the deity of Christ

× The root: dualism

Spirit is good, matter is evil — so there can be no God-Man

Paul answers every one of these with a Person: Christ is all, and Christ is enough.

Two errors about Jesus — one answer

Background I.B.1–2 · Where dualism leads

The Cerinthians
a man, but not God

Named for their founder, Cerinthus

"The Christ," a spirit, came upon Jesus at His baptism and left before the cross

The man Jesus died only as a man

A mere man cannot die for the world

vs

The Docetists
δοκέω dokeō · "to seem" — God, but not man

Jesus was only God

He only seemed to have a body

God, in His divine nature, cannot die

No real body means no real death for sin

"In Him all the fullness of Deity dwells in bodily form" (2:9) — fully God and fully man, one Person forever.

Grace in four dimensions, peace in three

Colossians 1:2 · Outline II.D — The salutation

Grace
χάρις charis · G5485

Saving grace — forgiveness and eternal life to all who believe (Eph 2:8–9)

Sanctifying grace — conforming us to the image of the Son

Serving grace — acceptable service only by grace (Heb 12:28)

Sharing grace — the generous giving of the Macedonians (2 Cor 8:1–7)

Peace
εἰρήνη eirēnē · G1515 · Heb. shalom

Peace with God — settled at justification by faith (Rom 5:1)

The God of peace — company for a godly walk (Phil 4:9)

The peace of God — a guard over heart and mind in hard circumstances (Phil 4:6–7)

Peace with God is a fact, not a feeling. The peace of God stands guard between us and the problem.

Faith, love and hope — three directions

Colossians 1:4–5a · Outline III.B — The reasons for thanksgiving

Faith looks up	Love looks out	Hope looks ahead
πίστις Rests on the past — the finished work of Christ. Its object is a Person.	**ἀγάπη** Works in the present — toward “all the saints,” not an inner circle	**ἐλπίς · ἀπόκειμαι** Confident expectation, “laid up” — stored and reserved in heaven
v.4a · “in Christ Jesus”	v.4b	v.5a

They loved “because of the hope laid up for you in heaven.” Assurance is not a barrier to love — it fuels it.

The gospel they first heard

Colossians 1:5b–6 · Outline III.C — The source of it all

A **Its universality · v.6a**

“Has come to you, just as in all the world also” — not a private message for an elite

B **Its productivity · v.6b**

καρποφορέω
“Constantly bearing fruit and increasing” — of itself, by its own life

C **Its individuality · v.6c**

“Even as it has been doing in you also” — the worldwide message became personal

D **Its identity · v.6d**

“The grace of God in truth” — add anything to grace and it is no longer the gospel

The Colossians didn’t need a newer, deeper, more exclusive message. The gospel they first heard was enough.

Epaphras: the man God used

Colossians 1:7–8 · Outline III.D — The messenger

1	**A student of Paul** “Just as you learned it from Epaphras” — trained in Ephesus, he carried the message home	**v.7a** learner, then teacher
2	**A beloved fellow bond-servant** Paul does not rank himself above him — slaves of the same Master	**σύνδουλος** co-slave
3	**A faithful servant of Christ** NASB95: “on our behalf” — he went in Paul’s place. NKJV: “on your behalf.” Either way, faithful.	**διάκονος** servant
4	**A messenger from them** “He also informed us of your love in the Spirit” — love produced by the Holy Spirit	**v.8** Spirit-given love

Before Paul answers a single error, he thanks God for grace at work — and for the man who brought it.

Discuss and apply

Colossians 1:1–8 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. Why would the Colossian heresy's view of matter lead to a wrong view of Jesus — and why does that matter for salvation?

2. According to verse 5, why did the Colossians love all the saints? What does that suggest about assurance and love?

Apply

Let Your Hope Fuel Your Love
Choose one person in your church you seldom speak with and do one concrete act of kindness for them.

Thank God for Your Epaphras
Send a short note of thanks this week to the person who brought you the gospel.

In one line: The gospel of grace first heard is true, worldwide and fruitful — and the Christ it proclaims is enough.